

Individual Reflection #1 Recap

January 21, 2026

TA: Alice

Everyone who submitted this assignment did a very good job!



early childhood language development

higher education policy

special education

teacher preparation

historically underrepresented students

LGBTQ community

family engagement

(1) Be mindful of word choice when framing your research questions.

- conflated association relationships with causal questions
- “lead to,” “affect,” “influence,” “impact,” “determine,” “result in,” “cause,” and “due to”, explanatory or causal claims
- associations or correlations between variables
 - “To what extent are factors A, B, and C associated with outcome(s) E, F, and G?”
 - “Is there an association between predictors A, B, and C and outcome(s) E, F, and G?”
 - “What is the relationship between factors A, B, and C and outcome(s) E, F, and G?”

(2) When posing descriptive research questions, clearly specify the type of information you seek.

- distributions (e.g., percentages, counts, or frequencies)
- measures of central tendency (e.g., mean, median, mode)
- variability and differences (e.g., standard deviation, variance, or covariance).

(3) Clearly state the research context in your questions.

- **Where**: K–12 setting (at what level), or in higher education
- **Who**: historically underrepresented students or faculty?
- **What**: key interest predictors and outcomes

(4) be intentional about how you operationalize your key constructs.

- measurement choice ~ research significance, theoretical framework, and study goals.
- E.g., community cultural wealth ~ asset-based college success
- Consider the following self-check questions:
 - Does this measure truly capture what I care about **theoretically**?
 - Will this operationalization help me address my **significance statement**?
 - Am I unintentionally excluding or overlooking the **populations or mechanisms** I claim to prioritize?
 - Does this choice move my research toward **actionable findings for practice**?